

office and play the "what-if game" among themselves, moving around our debits and credits, speculating what might happen if, for instance, we bought life insurance, transferred some assets to the children, or put more savings into Treasury bills. He called the what-if game "intermediation."

I volunteered to stop paying the gardener and start mowing the lawn myself, but Mr. Leffert said don't be silly, that was premature and too simplistic. It sounded as if M. H. Senzel & Co. would apply as many calculations to our household accounts as routinely go into the budgeting of major corporations. Even after our plan was completed, we'd have to come in twice a year for checkups, just like at the dentist. Mr. Leffert said that putting us on this review schedule was essential, or else the entire effort might be wasted.

So far, there'd been no mention of the cost of all this. Mr. Leffert seemed to be saving that information for last. When I asked him about the fee, he delved a bit further into the importance of the review schedule, the "totally integrated whole," and the expert perspective. He tried to smooth the path with references to "time," "effort," and "a lot of things the client doesn't see happening." Finally, he admitted that the fee for an initial plan could vary from 2 to 4 percent of our total family assets—depending on how much we had to begin with. After that, the firm would charge 1 to 2 percent per year for the follow-ups and the checkups.

His reminder that this was tax-deductible was only slightly reassuring. Being careful not to say anything about getting rich, I wondered out loud if the plan might at least provide us with enough extra income to cover the cost of planning. Mr. Leffert was certain the plan would save us money, but how that might be invested depended on our money manager. Here was another professional that we'd need.

The firm had its own money managers who were part of the bargain, but Mr. Leffert said I'd be free to go out and choose my own. He cautioned that it's as hard to find a good money manager as it is to find a good financial planner, so I'd have to do a lot of research into performance, fees, and the like before I could make an intelligent choice. Probably I'd be better off working with the professionals in-house.